

# The Indus

*One of Asia's major river systems, crossing the Himalayas and running the entire length of Pakistan*



One of the greatest Asian rivers, the Indus is about 1,980 miles (3,180 km) long, and its catchment basin drains an area of more than 425,000 square miles (1.1 million square km).

From its source near Lake Manasarovar on the Tibetan Plateau, the Indus flows northwest through the disputed territory of Jammu and Kashmir, turns southwest to enter Pakistan, and passes through a series of huge canyons near the Nanga Parbat Massif on its journey across the Himalayas. Emerging from the mountains as a fast-flowing river, the Indus descends onto the Punjab Plain, where it is joined by some of its major tributaries and begins to move slowly across a vast floodplain. During the monsoon season, the Indus can grow to a couple of miles wide in places. As it approaches the Arabian Sea, the river branches into the many distributaries that form the Indus River Delta.

## ▷ RIVER CONFLUENCE

In a mountainous region in its upper reaches, the Indus (bottom) meets the Zaskar, a major tributary, near Nimmu in northern India.



# The Ganges

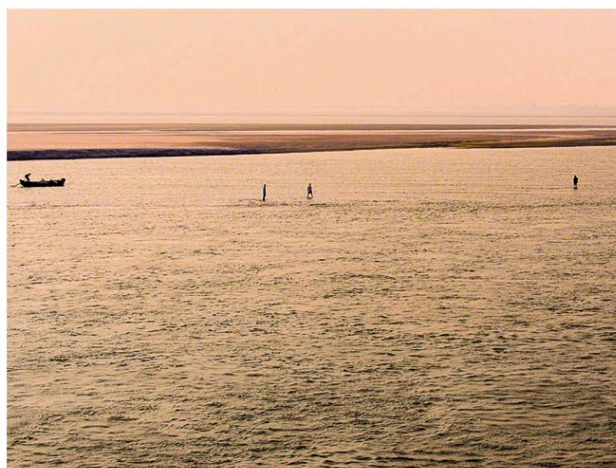
*One of the world's great waterways, a holy river and a place of pilgrimage*



The Ganges is the spiritual and physical lifeblood of India. Considered sacred and worshipped by Hindus, it is thought to support up to one-tenth of the world's population. After the Amazon and the Congo, it is the third largest river on Earth, measured by discharge.

## Winding journey

The Ganges flows more than 1,600 miles (2,500 km) across the Indian subcontinent. It forms in the north Indian state of Uttarakhand after the confluence of several ice-fed Himalayan rivers. After passing through narrow mountain valleys, it emerges on the vast Indo-Gangetic Plain to the east of Delhi. From here, it slowly meanders across a wide alluvial plain, passing many centers of holy pilgrimage including Allahabad and Varanasi, toward Bangladesh, where it is joined by the Brahmaputra and Meghna Rivers. The river system subsequently fans out into the largest delta system on Earth, depositing the greatest sediment load of any river into the Bay of Bengal.



## △ BROAD FLOODPLAIN

The middle course of the Ganges winds sluggishly across a vast floodplain. Over a distance of more than 1,000 miles (1,600 km), the river falls by only about 590 ft (180 m).

## △ COASTAL NETWORK

Seen here in dark green, the Sundarbans ecoregion stretches inland about 50 miles (80 km). It is largely bordered to the north by farmland.

## ▷ EXPOSED ROOTS

These black mangrove trees have developed aerial roots called pneumatophores, which project into the air during low tide.

